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## The Spontaneous Body

Silently standing in perennial mist and tropical verdure, Mt Luofu was where the ancient Daoist Ge Hong spent his final years experimenting on an alchemical elixir that would ultimately grant him immortality. Legend had it that he succeeded.<sup>1</sup> When Su Shi – aged, tired and disillusioned – was banished to Huizhou, he interpreted the destination of his journey as a sign of fate’s urging his final commitment to the arcane science.

This book’s last chapter is about the last chapter of Su Shi’s life: his escape from, and ultimate reconciliation with, death. In Su Shi’s conceptual world, immortals were real or possibly real beings. An immortal’s body was the fully spontaneous body, free from anxiety, disease and even the restrictions of a concrete material form. If the exoteric pursuit of spontaneity ended with the model of Tao Qian, the esoteric pursuit of spontaneity ended with that of Ge Hong.

Mainstream Chinese literature is generally reluctant to discuss Su Shi’s Daoist devotion in the last stage of his life, wary of it being ‘superstitious’.<sup>2</sup> In English literature, Ronald Egan has given this issue some well-balanced consideration.<sup>3</sup> However, Egan did not pay heed to the periodisation in Su Shi’s commitment to alchemical practices, the techniques that he employed, or the context of alchemical beliefs and practices handed down through history. Without a careful examination of such beliefs and practices, an important aspect of Su Shi’s life, as well as many of his literary works (especially those writ-

1 See Fang Xuanling, *Jinshu*, 72.1911–3.

2 For instance, Zhu Jinghua 朱靖華 does not touch upon his Daoist practice at all. At best he only mentions his “integration” of Chan Buddhism and Zhuangzian Daoism to transcend suffering; see Zhu Jinghua 朱靖華, *Su Shi xin lun* 蘇軾新論 (Jinan: Qilu shushe, 1983), 13–6, 428–30. A similar case is Leng Chengjin, *Su Shi de zhexue guan*, 324–7. Zeng Zaozhuang 曾枣庄, *Su Shi pingzhuan* 蘇軾評傳 (Chengdu: Sichuan renmin chubanshe, 1984) similarly circumvents this issue. Wang Shuizhao 王水照 only mentions how “others” suggested Su Shi practise the Daoist art of longevity; see *Su Shi zhuan: zhizhe zai kunan zhong de chaoyue* 蘇軾傳：智者在苦難中的超越 (Tianjin: Tianjin renmin chubanshe, 2000), 541. He and Zhu Gang 朱剛 further maintain that Su used Daoist methods only for health reasons. See Wang Shuizhao, *Su Shi zhuan*, 570; Wang Shuizhao and Zhu Gang, *Su Shi pingzhuan* 蘇軾評傳 (Nanjing: Nanjing daxue chubanshe, 2004), 118.

3 See Egan, *Word, Image, and Deed*, 237–50.

ten in Huizhou), is liable to be poorly understood. This chapter is a preliminary attempt to correct the academic oversight.

As I argue, Su Shi's pursuit of immortality was part of his efforts to explore the unknown and to fathom his fate. It was also consistent with his pursuit of spontaneity in art and in life. An 'immortal' (*xian* 仙)<sup>4</sup> not only lives for an extremely long time, he also lives in complete spiritual and physical freedom. Paradoxically, in the pursuit of such freedom, every stage requires ardent ritual practice in induced meditation. Regardless of whether immortality is fated or achieved, even those whose chance of immortality is written require dedicated practice. Those less lucky may achieve extreme longevity through meticulous care. Yet, such efforts are not to 'interfere' with one's fate. To be truly spontaneous, when death comes, one should readily resign to one's fate without further ado. The pursuit of immortality reveals a dynamic structure of practice and resignation, resulting in the kind of spontaneity which is provisional and conditioned by human imperfection.

This chapter first gives a chronological account of Su Shi's Daoist devotion and examines the various techniques he used, including laboratory and physiological alchemy. Then it discusses the various literary precursors that he chose to follow, each giving a conflicting view of death and immortality. An esoteric discourse on 'the Dragon and the Tiger' practice that he wrote in Huizhou is carefully analysed; and his building of a house on the White Crane Peak is seen as the culmination of his commitment to the pursuit of immortality. However, his further exile to Hainan falsified his reading of destiny, resulting in his resolution to the active immersion in the transience, and his final resignation to fate.

### The Amateur Alchemist before Mt Luofu

Among Song literati, Daoist practice in varying degrees of dedication was common. Even though the Zhao imperial house of the Song did not promote themselves as the descendants of Laozi, like the Li house of the Tang did, several emperors were devoted adepts, under whose patronage the Daoist scriptures

4 The Chinese notion of *xian* does not necessarily imply they never die. They may live for a few hundred years or achieve seeming immortality – that is, living as long as Heaven and Earth exist. Here, the term 'immortal' is used as an apologetic counterpart for *xian*, as becoming immortal is the practitioner's ultimate goal (implied in the alternative term for the Daoist art: *busi zhishu* 不死之術, or 'the technique of undying').

were first collected, edited and published in an encyclopaedic fashion.<sup>5</sup> Their effort set an example for the literati and facilitated their access to the texts.

Daoism as a popular religion permeated people's daily life. The child Su Shi was initially schooled in a local Daoist temple at Mt Qingcheng and studied with the Daoist priest Zhang Yijian 張易簡. Half a century later, exiled to Danzhou, one night he had a dream in which he went back to that temple and heard a pupil reading *Laozi*,<sup>6</sup> which he must have read as a child. The greying poet remembered that, at a tender age, he was fond of Daoism. Were it not for his father, who obligated him into marriage and civil service, he would have spirited himself away into the mountains and become a hermit.<sup>7</sup> However, retrospective memory is not always reliable. Perhaps Su Shi selectively magnified elements of the past to establish a consistent narrative of his life, make his final dedication to the Daoist art in Huizhou and Danzhou appear to be a certain 'return', and reduce his worldly glory to unfortunate aberration. As he said, "reading my youthful compositions, they resemble events happening in another life or the writing of someone else".<sup>8</sup> He disowned the words that brought him fame and declared his exile an opportunity to realise his true self. By this mental device, he interpreted misfortune as the source of happiness.

As a matter of fact, Su Shi's Daoist practice before Huizhou was inconsistent and half-hearted, foreboding nothing like a final return.<sup>9</sup> A poem written in 1059 mentioned his reading of *Huangtingjing* 黃庭經 (the Yellow Court Scripture),<sup>10</sup> a canon which established the essential theories of Daoist 'inner

5 The first encyclopaedia of this kind, *Yunji qiqian* 雲笈七籤, was a collection in 120 fascicles compiled by Zhang Junfang 張君房 (*jinsi* 1005), and presented to Zhenzong 真宗 (968–1022; r. 997–1022) in 1019. It represented a 'core collection' among the anarchic assemblage of texts loosely called 'Daoist'. The imperial patronage of compiling Daoist texts continued until the end of Northern Song, culminating in the *Wanshou daoze* 萬壽道藏 in 5,481 fascicles and published in block printing in 1116–17. See Chen Guofu 陳國符, *Daoze yuanliu kao* 道藏源流考 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1963), 134–6.

6 See Su Shi, "Zhongmiaotang ji" 眾妙堂記, *SSWJ*, 11.361–2.

7 See Su Shi, "Yu Liu Yiweng shijun shu" 與劉宜翁使君書, *SSWJ*, 49.1415–16; "Yu Wang Xiang wushou" 與王庠五首, no. 1, *SSWJ*, 60.1820.

8 See Su Shi, "Yu Wang Xiang wushou", no. 1, *SSWJ*, 60.1820.

9 Zhong Laiyin's 鐘來因 *Su Shi yu daoia daoiao* 蘇軾與道家道教 (Taipei: Xuesheng shuju, 1990), so far the most detailed study of Su Shi's Daoist practices, unfortunately takes his devotional acclamation uncritically and gives a partisan reading of his biography.

10 See Su Shi, "Liu ti Xianduguan" 留題仙都觀, *SSSJ*, 1.18–9. The Yellow Court (*huangting* 黃庭) is a Daoist term referring to the fictive middle space of the human body. It is named as such because yellow represents 'middle' in the Five Phases (*wuxing* 五行) cosmology, while the court is the (political and cosmological) middle of the world. It usually corre-

alchemy' (*neidan* 內丹), or physiological alchemy. This term is dichotomous with 'outer alchemy' (*waidan* 外丹), or laboratory alchemy.<sup>11</sup> The Northern Song saw a general transition from laboratory to physiological alchemy. From the second century BCE to the Late Tang, laboratory alchemy had been in dominance. Its theory, roughly speaking, was based upon using the alchemist stove as a microcosmos in which various minerals were tempered into alchemist gold. The ingestion of 'cinnabar pellets', made of alchemist gold, was supposed to transform the human body into durable materials that defied decay.<sup>12</sup> The minerals used to make cinnabar pellets, however, were highly poisonous. Many practitioners, including emperors, were victims of 'cinnabar poisoning'. Their deaths were often interpreted by Daoists – makers and peddlers of these pellets – as "deliverance from the corpse" (*shijie* 尸解).<sup>13</sup> In contrast, inner alchemy recommended a safer and cheaper approach. The body of an inner alchemist was interpreted as a microcosmos itself; its various parts corresponded to cosmic elements and its functioning mimicked that of an alche-

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sponds to the spleen. It is also sometimes said to consist of three parts, corresponding respectively to the middle of the brain, the heart and the spleen. See *Shangqing huangting neijing jing* 上清黃庭內景經, in Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, 190, 197; Schipper, *Taoist Body*, 106; Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 57. Another theory is that three 'Yellow Courts' are located within the head, the spleen and the lower Cinnabar Field (*dantian* 丹田); see Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 57. Cinnabar Field refers to the source of energy in the body. It usually corresponds to the place three inches below the navel; though, according to the principle of triadic unity, there are another two cinnabar fields in the cerebral and thoracic sections of the body. See *Shangqing huangting neijing jing*, in Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, 11.232, 235.

11 *Dan* 丹, or elixir, literally means (red) cinnabar, since cinnabar is a main ingredient in producing alchemist gold. Here, I use the common definitions of *neidan* and *waidan* in modern scholarship; see, e.g., Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, xxiv. However, examined from a historical viewpoint, the exact boundary between *waidan* and *neidan* remains flexible, and the terminologies of laboratory alchemy are often used metaphorically in describing the process of physiological alchemy. See Isabelle Robinet, "Sur le sens des termes *waidan* et *neidan*", *Taoist Resources* (1991), 3.1: 4–5, 31–2. For further information, see also Farzeen Baldrian Hussein, "Inner Alchemy: Notes on the Origin and Use of the Term *neidan*", *Cahiers d'Extrême-Asie* (1989), 5: 187.

12 See Wang Ming, *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 4.71–2.

13 "Deliverance from the corpse" is one way a Daoist practitioner could become an immortal, that is, he pretends to have died by discarding a corpse, while his spirit roams free. See Isabelle Robinet, "Metamorphosis and Deliverance from the Corpse in Taoism", *History of Religion* (1979), 19.1: 37–70. According to Chen Guofu, in the Tang, many died from cinnabar poisoning and Daoist priests were aware of the harm. Thus, they produced those pellets mainly for profit, not for their own consumption. See Chen Guofu, *Daozang*, 383–4, 388–9, 391–2.

mist stove.<sup>14</sup> Inner alchemy became the mainstream since Song times.<sup>15</sup> Su's alchemical exercise was mainly physiological. His method would eventually combine respiratory control, abstinence, meditation, gymnastics and gathering the cosmic essence of the sun and the moon, aided by the intake of herbal medicine.

In 1063, during his first official tenure at Fengxiang, Su Shi had the opportunity to visit the Daoist library in the Shangqing Taiping Temple 上清太平宮, and read its collection of scriptures. He depicted a rich library of a thousand boxes wrapped in blue silk, which he must have read selectively. He seemed to be primarily interested in meditation techniques.<sup>16</sup> If this library also collected books on laboratory alchemy, he did not mention them.

Yet his early interest seemed to reflect more intellectual curiosity than belief. In the two decades prior to his Huangzhou exile, Su Shi remained an inactive practitioner. In contrast, his younger brother, Su Che, started practising inner alchemy from 1071 (because of his lung disease), and showed great dedication.<sup>17</sup> In 1077, when they met in Xuzhou, Che surprised Shi by his achievement in practice.<sup>18</sup> Su Shi admired Che's focus, as he himself was easily distracted.<sup>19</sup> Only after he was exiled to Huangzhou did he take a solemn oath to abjure worldly engagement and sensual pleasures. At the end of 1080, further alarmed by his eye disease and early signs of ageing, he retreated to the Daoist Tianqing Temple 天慶觀 for an uninterrupted forty-nine days of meditation.<sup>20</sup> He blithely told his disciple, "Were it not for the dismissal and exile, how could I have managed to do this?"<sup>21</sup>

One practice that Su Shi attempted in Huangzhou was to gather the cosmic essence of the sun and the moon. In the Daoist universe of general correspondences, the body is a microcosmos in a triadic unity (*sanyi* 叁一): the cerebral, the thoracic and the abdominal.<sup>22</sup> The sun and the moon, as heavenly bodies,

14 See Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 82. For graphs representing an alchemist body, see Needham and Lu, *Spagyrical Discovery*, 68–72.

15 See Zhong Laiyin, *Su Shi*, 4–7; Chen Guofu, *Daozang*, 393–4.

16 Su Shi, "Du daoang" 讀道藏, *SSSJ*, 4.181–2.

17 *SSNP*, 89.

18 *Ibid.*, 147, 155.

19 See Su Shi, "Chubie Ziyong" 初別子由, *SSSJ*, 15.757–9.

20 See Su Shi, "Yu Teng Dadao liushibashou" 與滕達道六十八首, no. 22, *SSWJ*, 51.1481–2; "Da Qin Taixu qishou" 答秦太虛七首, no. 4, *SSWJ*, 52.1535.

21 Su Shi, "Da Qin Taixu qishou", no. 4, *SSWJ*, 52.1535.

22 According to Isabelle Robinet, the polyvalence of symbols is caused by their applicability to different levels or stages in the process of progressive spiritualisation, depending on where the adept starts his meditation (whether focus is on the lower or upper part of the

metaphorically refer primarily to the eyes (located in the cerebral section), but also to inner lights shining upon the landscapes in the practitioner's middle and lower body sections. Methods of this practice vary. But, in general, such methods recommend standing facing the sun or the moon and visualising its presence, circulation and accumulation inside the human body – often accompanied by respiratory control and salivary deglutition.<sup>23</sup> Su Shi aimed to absorb the cosmic essence to strengthen the corresponding organs in the body.<sup>24</sup> He might only have read about such practices from books, as he admitted that he did not know the proper mantra accompanying this practice – so he invented one himself.<sup>25</sup> Oral transmission contributes to the self-perpetuating mystery of the occult science. Daoist canons are often written in deliberated abstruse language or in ecliptic fashion, so that orally transmitted mantras (*koujue* 口訣) are necessary in order to understand the written instructions.<sup>26</sup> Su Shi's 'invention' of a mantra seems to suggest either his extreme confidence or utter playfulness.

Encouraged by his progress in physiological alchemy, Su Shi eventually requested cinnabar from his old friend and fellow practitioner Wang Dingguo 王定國,<sup>27</sup> who lived in Guangxi. He had ambitions to make the elixir of immortality: 'the Golden Cinnabar' (*jindan* 金丹).<sup>28</sup> He seconded the argument that true immortality is attainable only by taking the Golden Cinnabar, or 'Great Drug' (*dayao* 大藥), a theory advanced by Ge Hong in *Baopuzi* 抱朴子 (Master Who Embraces Simplicity). Ge Hong argued that herbs and other efficacious natural materials were all 'minor drugs' (*xiaoyao* 小藥) that only guaranteed longevity, but not genuine *xian*-hood.<sup>29</sup> Only by taking the cinnabar, tempered nine times in the alchemist stove (or by taking multiple doses of cinnabar tempered fewer times), could the practitioner take his thoroughly

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body); see Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 52. This triadic unity of the body can be explained by the principle of "Three-One"; see *ibid.*, 125–6, 187–8.

23 See Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, 23.532–8. Needham and Lu called it "actino-therapeutic complex" or "phototherapeutic procedures"; see *Spagyric Discovery*, 31–2, 181–4.

24 On such practices, see Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, 182–4.

25 Su Shi, "Cai ri Yuehua zan" 採日月華贊, *SSWJ*, 21.617.

26 As exhorted by Ge Hong; see *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 14.155–6; mentioned also in Fabrizio Pregadio, *Great Clarity: Daoism and Alchemy in Early Medieval China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2006), 80.

27 Wang Dingguo was Su's childhood playmate who was keen in practising the Daoist art. See Su Shi, "Zai Pengcheng ri yu Dingguo wei Jiuri Huangzhou zhihui [...]" 在彭城日與定國爲九日黃樓之會, *SSWJ*, 35.1904.

28 Su Shi, "Yu Wang Dingguo sishiyishou" 與王定國四十一首, no. 8, *SSWJ*, 52.1517–8.

29 See "Jindan", *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 4.70–2.



transformed body to transcendence. Wang Dingguo might have tried to dissuade Su Shi from making the elixir at home, when Su Shi urged him to send cinnabar twice more.<sup>30</sup> Su Shi reassured him that he would never dare take the pellets, but making them would entertain him in idleness. As will be seen later, it is likely that he continued his secret experiments in Huizhou, a fact that suggests his long-lasting, albeit cautious, fascination with laboratory alchemy.

After his Huangzhou exile, the death of Shenzong brought him back to the centre of politics. Su spent the following eight years in a series of successful metropolitan appointments. Efficacious medicines were sometimes presented to him in return for a favour or a price. Once he received a ‘flesh fungus’ (*rouzhi* 肉芝) that had the form of a baby’s arm. According to Ge Hong, taking a ‘flesh fungus’ guaranteed immediate immortality.<sup>31</sup> Su Shi cooked it and preciousely shared it with his brother. The promised immortality, however, did not come. Instead of doubting the efficacy of the elixir, Su Shi suspected that immortality could not be won so easily. He wrote a poem to lament that, like an old silk-worm trapped in its cocoon, he was only dreaming of the supreme beings with vain intensity.<sup>32</sup> Surely, if the Great Drug could be offered or purchased, then the realm of transcendence would have long been teeming with the powerful and the rich. He also speculated that perhaps he should not have cooked it, as herbal elixirs were better digested raw.<sup>33</sup>

In the metropolitan days, his schedule filled with official and social obligations, Su Shi’s practice of meditation was sporadic. He lamented that his “square-inch [Cinnabar] Field is overgrown with thorny shrubs” and longed to return to his “authentic nature”.<sup>34</sup> Thus, when his career suffered yet another abrupt strike, Su Shi optimistically interpreted it as an opportunity, as well as a mandate, to reengage with his long-abandoned pursuit. Better still, he was exiled to Huizhou, the cinnabar-producing site where Ge Hong attained transcendence. He saw it a sign. On crossing the Dayu Range 大庾嶺, a fortified mountain separating the miasmic Guangdong from the central plains, he wrote:

一念失垢污  
身心洞清淨  
浩然天地間

A single thought purges all stains of filth;  
the body and mind become thoroughly pure.  
Between the lofty Heaven, the vast Earth,

30 Su Shi, “Yu Wang Dingguo sishiyishou”, no. 9, no. 12, *SSWJ*, 52.1519, 1520.

31 See “Xianyao” 仙藥, *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 11.201.

32 See Su Shi, “Shizhi” 石芝, *SSSJ*, 37.2001–2.

33 See ch. 4, 153.

34 Su Shi, “Liubie Jian daoshi Gongchen” 留別蹇道士拱辰, *SSSJ*, 33.1765.



惟我獨也正  
今日嶺上行  
身世永相忘  
仙人拊我頂  
結髮受長生

I am solitary and just.  
Today I am crossing the mountain range,  
and shall since forget my origin, my past.  
The immortal lays his hand on my head,  
tying my hair into a knot, I hereby receive the endless  
life.<sup>35</sup>

The poetic persona resembles Qu Yuan, the slandered moral hero, as well as Li Bo 李白 (701–762), the ‘exiled immortal’. The last couplet is borrowed from a poem by Li Bo on his way to exile in Yelang 夜郎 (now Huaihua, in Hunan Province). Li’s poem fictively recalls his admission into the rank of immortals; ‘by mistake’ he indulges himself in sensual pleasures and is banished to the world of man.<sup>36</sup> Su Shi, citing Li Bo’s poem, wishes to return to the state of blessed purity. Written at the moment of crossing the symbolic boundary between the centre and the periphery, this poem sublimates his sense of guilt, announces his innocence, and expresses a resolution to transcend mundane losses or gains.

As a man of letters, Su was convinced of his destiny only in reference to precedence. Another precedence was established by Bo Juyi:

Letian [aka. Bo Juyi] once built a thatched hut in Mt Lu, also intending to make cinnabar pellets. When his undertaking was about to succeed, the stove and the tripod exploded. The next day, an edict arrived, appointing him Magistrate of Zhongzhou. So he knew that businesses in and out of the world were incompatible. I have had a similar resolution for a long time but never succeeded. It was also because my business in the world had not failed. Now it has thoroughly failed. The *Documents* says, “What man desires, Heaven grants”. It proves to be true.

樂天作廬山草堂，蓋亦燒丹也，欲成而爐鼎敗。來日，忠州刺史除書到。乃知世間、出世間事，不兩立也。僕有此志久矣，而終無成者，亦以世間事未敗故也，今日真敗矣。《書》曰：“民之所欲，天必從也。”信而有徵。<sup>37</sup>

35 Su Shi, “Guo Dayuling” 過大庾嶺, *SSSJ*, 38.2056–7.

36 See Li Bo, “Jing luanli hou tian'en liu Yelang yi jiuyou shuhuai zeng Jiangxia Wei Taishou Liangzai” 經亂離後天恩流夜郎憶舊游書懷贈江夏韋太守良宰, *Li Taibai quanji* 李太白全集 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1977), 11.567.

37 “Letian shaodan” 樂天燒丹, in Su Shi, *Dongpo zhili* 東坡志林, 1.11–2.

In a pattern now familiar to us, Su Shi argued that Heaven was felicitous to let him be exiled, so that he could realise what he had always desired. His exile was as much fated as willed. In this way, he claimed agency for his suffering and, rhetorically, became the master of his fate.

### Reading Destiny

In Huizhou, Su Shi worked more intensively on his commentary on the *Book of Changes*. His commentary very definitely broke away from the *Zhouyi cantongqi* 周易參同契 (Concordance of the Three, Commentary on the *Book of Changes*)<sup>38</sup> tradition that read this classic in ‘imagery and numerology’ (*xiangshu* 象數) terms, and had had an important influence on inner alchemical works since the Tang.<sup>39</sup> Su Shi was not interested in calculating fate. He admitted in a treatise that the *Changes* was initially a divinatory book and numerology was important in carrying its message; yet Confucius’ commentary (*xici* 繫辭) set up an example of rationality,<sup>40</sup> and Su Shi’s followed suit. He argued that speculating about one’s fate was not only difficult (if not impossible), but also superfluous. Fate (*ming* 命) had nothing to do with human aspiration (*zhi* 志); one could only employ oneself to the utmost extent of one’s abilities, and allow whatever came to come. By doing so, however, there was a chance that human endeavours could overcome heavenly mandated fate.<sup>41</sup>

Yet, even if fate is unknowable, there are only three possibilities concerning the ultimate question of death: immortality, (extreme) longevity or (normal) mortality. These three aspirations are respectively represented by the theories of three figures whom Su Shi regarded as his paragons: Ge Hong, Ji Kang and Tao Qian.

Ge Hong argued that human cognitive capacity is limited, so the origin of things or immortality is beyond our perceptive scope. What is observable, however, is the constancy of transformation. It follows that a man can transform his corruptible body into something more durable, so that he will live

38 A work credited to a certain Wei Boyang 魏伯陽 of Late Eastern Han, but perhaps written by different hands and compiled over time. On the author and periodisation of this book, see *Wangu danjing wang: Zhouyi cantongqi sanshisijia zhushi jicui* 萬古丹經王：《周易參同契》三十四家註釋集萃, eds. Meng Naichang 孟乃昌 and Meng Qingxuan 孟慶軒 (Beijing: Huaxia chubanshe, 1993), 30–48.

39 Su Shi’s occasional reference to the *Cantongqi* system was not necessarily due to his study of this work, given that *Cantongqi* was a seminal work whose system prevailed in discussions of inner alchemy.

40 Su Shi, “Yilun” 易論, *sswJ*, 2:52–3.

41 Su Shi, *Su shi Yi zhuan*, in *San Su quanshu*, vol. 1, 283–4, 290.

longer or forever.<sup>42</sup> And, since all men are endowed with the same luminous intelligence (*mingzhe* 明哲), everyone can potentially become an immortal.<sup>43</sup> As it is said that Ge Hong became an immortal on Mt Luofu, Su Shi wrote on his first excursion to this mountain:

|         |                                                        |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| 東坡之師抱朴老 | The Old Man Who Embraces Simplicity is truly           |
|         | Dongpo's teacher;                                      |
| 真契早已交前生 | our true correspondence has been bound in a former     |
|         | life.                                                  |
| 玉堂金馬久流落 | I have long wandered away from Jade Hall and Golden    |
|         | Horse Gate; <sup>44</sup>                              |
| 寸田尺宅今歸耕 | now I return to a foot-high house and plough a square- |
|         | inch field. <sup>45</sup>                              |

The “foot-high house” and “square-inch field” refer simultaneously to a tiny estate and, in Daoist parlance, to the face and the cinnabar field in the abdomen. It also implies that, consistent with his contemporary development, Su Shi rejected Ge Hong's preference for chemical alchemy and instead preferred inner alchemy. Yet Su lauded Ge Hong for his universalist approach to immortality, seeing it as evidence of the latter's Confucian compassion for all beings:

|       |                                                               |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 稚川雖獨善 | Though Zhichuan holds his virtue to him alone,                |
| 愛物均孔顏 | his compassion for things is just like that of Confucius      |
|       | and Yan Hui.                                                  |
| 欲使蟪蛄流 | He wants to let those cicada-like beings of short lives,      |
| 知有龜鶴年 | know about the longevity of turtles and cranes. <sup>46</sup> |

Ronald Egan mistakenly interprets this poem as Su Shi questioning Ge Hong's ‘worldly’ pursuit of longevity.<sup>47</sup> In effect, Su Shi literally borrows from Ge Hong. Arguing against an interlocutor who chides Ge's effort as futile, since no cica-

42 See “Lunxian” 論仙, *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 2.12–2. This argument is against Wang Chong's 王充 (27–97?) theory that immortals did not exist, since spiritual existence was not independent of the physical body; see Huang Hui 黃暉, *Lunheng jiaoshi* 論衡校釋 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1990), 20.871–3.

43 See “Duisu” 對俗, *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 3.46–54. The same argument is reiterated in *Lunheng jiaoshi*, 13.239–40.

44 The Jade Hall and Golden Horse Gate were buildings in Western Han palaces, and implied high academic positions in court.

45 Su Shi, “You Luofushan yishou shi erzi Guo” 游羅浮山一首示兒子過, *SSSJ*, 38.2069.

46 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Du Shanhaijing’”, no. 2, *SSSJ*, 39.2130–1.

47 Egan, *Word, Image and Deed*, 243.

da's life can be prolonged to over a year, Ge retorts that creatures like turtles and cranes can live forever (a popular belief); as beings are in constant transformation, just as birds become clams or rotten grass becomes fireflies (other popular beliefs),<sup>48</sup> why cannot a cicada change into a turtle or a crane?<sup>49</sup>

Yet Ge Hong's confidence in everyone's capacity to achieve immortality contradicted Su Shi's agnostic view that human cognitive capacity is limited. When Su Shi doubted that everyone could become an immortal, he resourcefully quoted Ji Kang who, in the "Treatise on Nourishing Life", argued that immortals did exist; however, only a chosen few were predestined for transcendence. Normal people, with extreme care, could extend their lifespan by up to one thousand years.<sup>50</sup> Su Shi repeatedly copied this treatise by hand. In a colophon to his handwritten copy, he wrote:

In the dimming sunlight among mulberries and elms, with the remnant of a life consumed by worries and suffering, Layman Dongpo has finally begun to study the Way. Though those of supreme understanding may laugh at me, it is still a wise thing to do for myself. Since Ji Shuye's [aka. Ji Kang] "Treatise on Nourishing Life" hits precisely upon my weakness, I have made a few hand-copies of it [...]

東坡居士以桑榆之末景，憂患之餘生，而後學道，雖爲達者所笑，然猶賢乎己也。以嵇叔夜《養生論》頗中余病，故手寫數本 [...]<sup>51</sup>

Ji Kang's argument, as cited earlier, is that it was a moral mandate to take care of one's physical wellbeing, just as a farmer should diligently irrigate his crops – even during a drought when their withering was inevitable. Even though not everyone may achieve immortality, one could prolong one's life significantly, up to a thousand years. Many understood, but could not practise, this doctrine because the demand was strict and the reward was remote.<sup>52</sup> Su Shi was especially touched by the 'crop' analogy and borrowed it a few times in his poetry.<sup>53</sup>

48 The "Yueling" 月令 chapter of the *Book of Rites* states that in the third month of summer, rotten grass turns into fireflies; in the third month of autumn, a sparrow dives into the water to become a clam. See Sun Xidan 孫希旦, *Liji jijie* 禮記集解 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1989), 16.456, 17.477.

49 See "Lunxian", *Baopuzi neipian jiaoshi*, 2.12–4.

50 See Dai Mingyang, *Ji Kang ji jiaozhu*, 3.143–4.

51 Su Shi, "Ba Ji Shuye 'Yangshenglun' hou" 跋嵇叔夜養生論後, *sswj*, 66.2056.

52 Ji Kang, "Yangshenglun", see Dai Mingyang, *Ji Kang ji jiaozhu*, 3.144–5, 154.

53 See ch. 4, 161.

Even though such devotion might have appeared foolish to those wise ones, he swore to do it for his own sake.

As for the third possibility, namely that whatever he did would ultimately fail, Su Shi turned to the example of Tao Qian, his primary role model of the time. Tao Qian famously proposed, *à la* the *Zhuangzi*, to

縱浪大化中  
不喜亦不懼

Surrender to the tide of the Great Transformation,  
with neither delight nor yet fear.<sup>54</sup>

In a poem where Su Shi first lauds Ge Hong's gospel that immortality is within every man's reach, he also then praises Tao Qian precisely for his lack of desire for immortality. Despite Tao's average lifespan, he "shared the lofty mind of the Cinnabar Hills" 雅志仍丹丘; disregarding the distinction between life and death, he transcended the flow of life. Tao and Ge represented two kinds of transcendence: the spiritual and the physical. At the end of the poem, Su Shi proposes to embrace both their models simultaneously, which suggests an ambiguity towards both attitudes.<sup>55</sup> He also announced that the three of them should form a new 'Picture of the Three Gentlemen' (*sanshi tu* 三士圖).<sup>56</sup> This famous topos in Chinese painting originally depicts the collegial society of Tao Qian, the Buddhist patriarch Huiyuan 慧遠 (334–416) and the Daoist master Lu Xiujing 陸修靜 (406–477).<sup>57</sup> Given the disparity between their times, this is mere legend. Nevertheless, it represents an ideal of friendship – based upon spiritual altitude and disregarding intellectual or religious persuasion. Su Shi now wanted to form another triadic society on Mt Luofu, with two authors whose different understandings of fate were, for him, equally true.<sup>58</sup>

54 Tao Qian, "Shen shi" 神釋, in "Xing ying shen" 形影神, *TYM*, 2.67.

55 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Du Shanhaijing'", no. 3, *SSSJ*, 39.2131.

56 See Su Shi, "He Tao 'Du Shanhaijing'", no. 1, *SSSJ*, 39.2130.

57 It was said that Huiyuan, during his secluded residence on Mt Lu, never crossed Tiger Creek (*Huxi* 虎溪) regardless of the guest's rank. One day Tao and Lu paid a visit. They were so immersed in animated discussion that, when sending the two guests off, Huiyuan was unaware that he had crossed Tiger Creek. The tiger roared in warning and the three gentlemen laughed. See "Donglin Shiba gaoxian zhuan" 東林十八高賢傳, 卅 no. 1543, 78.119c. See also the entry on Tiger Creek, Wu Zongci 吳宗慈, *Lushan zhi* 廬山志 (Nanchang: Jiangxi renmin chubanshe, 1996), vol. 1, 103–4.

58 Even though Su liked Ji Kang's treatise, he did not seem to have taken Ji as a role model, perhaps because Ji Kang was executed. His violent death would bode ill for an exile.

### Discourse on the Dragon and the Tiger

Soon after his arrival at Huizhou, Su Shi suffered again from severe haemorrhoids, a chronic ailment that had been torturing him for decades. To alleviate the pain, he followed a strict daily diet of unseasoned noodles, and crushed tuckahoe paste mixed with black sesame. Since a meagre diet was recommended for longevity, Su Shi – again – thanked his condition for giving him the extra incentive to do what he should.<sup>59</sup> As many immortals supposedly acquired transcendence in seeking a cure for their disease, Su Shi wistfully thought that his haemorrhoids might be a blessing in disguise.<sup>60</sup>

In addition to this diet, Su Shi sought to acquire efficacious medicine. His major benefactor was Cheng Zhicai 程之才, his maternal cousin who was appointed Judicial Commissioner of Guangdong. Given the feud between the two families,<sup>61</sup> Su's prosecutors probably dispatched Cheng to inflict further suffering upon Su. Cheng, however, used it as an opportunity to repair their broken family ties. In the extant seventy-four letters that Su sent to Cheng in just ten months,<sup>62</sup> a large number concerned exchanges of various types, including food, medicine and dietary supplements, as well as items obviously for laboratory purposes: mercury, sulphur, pine oleoresin, iron stove and pan.<sup>63</sup> These letters provide precious evidence of Su Shi's possible engagement in esoteric practices, otherwise unmentioned in his writing.

Su Shi was ostensibly more at ease in writing about physiological alchemy. His most extensive and systematic treatment on this topic is found in a "Discourse on the Dragon and the Tiger, or Lead and Mercury" (Longhu qiangong shuo 龍虎鉛汞說).<sup>64</sup> Written as a private letter to Su Che, this discourse carefully recounts an oral revelation from a certain 'hermit' (*yinzhe* 隱者) in 1096. The fact that Su Shi frequently referred to this revelation during this period, in various forms and degrees of exotericity – in a discourse, a treatise (to be dis-

59 See Su Shi, "Da Huang Luzih wushou" 答黃魯直五首, no. 4, *SSWJ*, 52.1533; "Yu Cheng Zhengfu qishiyishou" 與程正輔七十一首, no. 53, *SSWJ*, 54.1612.

60 See Su Shi, "Yao song" 藥誦, *SSWJ*, 64.1985.

61 Su Shi's elder sister was married to Cheng Zhicai and soon died, allegedly from maltreatment; see *SSNP*, 1.31. The Sus and the Chengs thus severed communication.

62 See Su Shi, "Yu Cheng Zhengfu qishiyishou", *SSWJ*, 54.1589–621; "Yu Cheng Zhengfu san-shou" 與程正輔三首, *SSWJ*, *yiven* 佚文 3.2488–9.

63 See Su Shi, "Yu Cheng Zhengfu qishiyishou", no. 28, no. 55, no. 71, *SSWJ*, 54.1599, 1615, 1621.

64 Su Shi, "Longhu qiangong shuo", *SSWJ*, 73.2331–3.

cussed later), three poems<sup>65</sup> and, perhaps, also orally<sup>66</sup> – underlines its significance. This discourse received certain attention in Western scholarship, but a complete translation with commentary is, so far, missing.<sup>67</sup> Below, I will translate and discuss the text in four sections.

[1] The life and death of humans all result from [the interactions of] the *kan* and *li* trigrams. When *kan* and *li* are coupled, we live; when they separate, we die. This is a law of necessity. *Kan* corresponds to the heart, and *li* to the kidneys. What the heart recognises as correct is always upright. This is the case with even [evil-doers like] King Jie and Robber Zhi. Their being Jie and Zhi was because their internal drives were weak, while their external drives were strong. Therefore they constantly practised what their hearts recognised as incorrect. When the kidneys are strong, their influence overflows; hence rise desires. This is the case with even [sages like] King Yao and Yan Hui. Their being Yao and Yan was because their internal drives were strong, while their external drives were weak. Therefore, they constantly practised what their hearts recognised as correct. From this point of view, the nature of the heart is disciplined and upright, while the nature of the kidneys is licentious and evil. Likewise are the virtues of water and fire. Zichan once said, “Fire is fierce, thus people, at the sight of it, fear it. Water is weak, thus people fiddle with it in disrespect”.<sup>68</sup> The wise men of the old all knew it well. The dragon is the mercury, the semen and the blood. It comes out of the kidneys and hides in the liver. It is a *kan* substance. The tiger is the lead, the breath and the strength. It comes out of the heart and is fostered by the lungs. It is a *li*

65 Three poems written in this period seem to be related to this revelation. See Su Shi, “Haishangdaoren chuan yishenshouqi jue” 海上道人傳以神守氣訣, *SSSJ*, 40.2209–10; “Zeng Chen Shoudao” 贈陳守道, *SSSJ*, 40.2210–1; and “Biandao ge” 辨道歌, *SSSJ*, 40.2211–2.

66 According to his note “Haishangdaoren chuan yishenshouqi jue”, Su sent this poem to Wu Ziye 吳子野, a fellow student of Daoist alchemy, in the first month of 1097; but, before that, he had already orally imparted its content to Wu in detail. See Zha Shenxing’s 查慎行 commentary under the title of this poem, *SSSJ*, 40.2209.

67 Arthur Waley translated part of this discourse as evidence that alchemy in Song China came to mean “a system of mental and physical reeducation”, see Arthur Waley, “Notes on Chinese Alchemy, Supplementary to Johnson’s ‘Study of Chinese Alchemy’”, *Bulletin of the School of Oriental Studies* (1930), 6.1: 15. Waley’s translation and argument are also quoted in Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, 22. Ronald Egan has discussed the general alchemical principle of the discourse, but does not translate the first two sections which outline this procedure in detail; see Egan, *Word, Image, and Deed*, 239.

68 *Zuozhuan*, Zhao 20; see *Chunqiu zuozhuan zhengyi*, 49.392, *SSJZS*, 2094.



substance. When the heart is set in motion, pneuma and strength arise together. When the kidneys overflow, semen and blood are emitted together. Just as smoke coming out of fire will never return into the wood [what is released will never return]. Common people do not study the Way. Their dragon often comes out of water, so when the dragon flies away, their share of mercury lightens. Their tiger often comes out of fire, so when the tiger escapes, their share of lead is exhausted. This is the constant principle of human life. Those who follow this course die. Those who reverse it become immortals. Therefore the Man of Truth says, “Following this course is humanity; reversing this course is the Way”. And again, “The art of reversing the Five Phases, is to let the dragon come out of fire. When the Five Phases run reverse – in water the tiger is born”.<sup>69</sup>

人之所以生死，未有不从坎、離者。坎、離交則生，分則死，必然之道也。離爲心，坎爲腎，心之所然，未有不正，雖桀、跖亦然。其所以爲桀、跖者，以內輕而外重，故常行其所不然者爾。腎強而溢，則有欲念，雖堯、顏亦然。其所以爲堯、顏者，以內重而外輕，故常行其所然者爾。由此觀之，心之性法而正，腎之性淫而邪，水火之德，固如是也。子產曰：“火烈，人望而畏之。水弱，人狎而侮之。”古之達者，未有不知此者也。龍者，汞也，精也，血也。出於腎，而肝藏之，坎之物也。虎者，鉛也，氣也，力也。出於心，而肺生之，離之物也。心動，則氣力隨之而作。腎溢，則精血隨之而流。如火之有烟，未有復反於薪者也。世之不學道，其龍常出於水，故龍飛而汞輕。其虎常出於火，故虎走而鉛枯。此生人之常理也。順此者死，逆此者仙。故真人之言曰：“順行則爲人，逆行則爲道。”又曰：“五行顛倒術，龍從火裏出。五行不順行，虎向水中生。”

Among the eight trigrams in the *Book of Changes*, the *qian* 乾, *kun* 坤, *kan* 坎 and *li* 離 trigrams have acquired the foremost significance in Daoist alchemy. In *Zhouyi cantongqi*, *qian* and *kun* are the ‘parents’ of all hexagrams, representing Heaven and Earth; but as origins they are hidden. *Kan* and *li* are their observable, exoteric manifestations in the transformations of the phenomenal world.<sup>70</sup> In the microcosmos of the human body, *kan* and *li* represent the binary vital forces. Death results from their daily separation, and immortality is

69 Cited from a certain Taoist immortal, Taibai zhenren 太白真人; see Shi Jianwu, 施肩吾, *Sishan qunxian huizhenji* 西山群仙會真記, 1.10.

70 Meng Naichang, *Wangu danjing wang*, 1, 26–7.

achieved only by reversing this natural course. Su Shi further relates these two primary forces to characterology. According to his physiological interpretation of human nature, the nature of a sage is not essentially different from that of common people. The nature of sages and villains alike consists of the same *kan* and *li* forces. The *li* force is the strongest in a sage, while in a villain, it is the *kan*. Yet both forces are needed to be human. Sages control, but do not eliminate, the evil power within each and every man. This theory of human nature provides a pseudo-scientific foundation for his ethics, as discussed in Chapter One. The heart and the kidneys are the respective hosting organs of *kan* and *li* forces. Lead and mercury, also called the ‘true (or vital) lead’ (*zhenqian* 真鉛), and the ‘true (or vital) mercury’ (*zhengong* 真汞),<sup>71</sup> are their manifestations; tiger and dragon, metaphors of their power.<sup>72</sup> In the forms of ferocious animals, the two forces devour human vitality from within. They are tamed if harmonised by each other. As the verse suggests, once the natural course of the Five Phases is reversed, the heart and the kidneys shall generate their opposite forces.

‘Reverse’ (*fan* 反) or ‘return’ (*gui* 歸) is a key notion in physiological alchemy. ‘Returning to infancy’ is an ancient Daoist slogan, as found in *Laozi*,<sup>73</sup> suggesting that human vitality is fully charged upon parturition and constantly discharges with every natural cycle of breath. In the Daoist vision of human life, a person is born at the moment of conception – thus a child’s age is determined not from the date of parturition, but from the beginning of gestation. A child therefore leads an ‘inner life’ inside the womb. This embryonic stage provides a model for a person’s whole lifespan.<sup>74</sup> As Robinet puts it,

[the human body is] the product of the condensation of the breaths of the Nine Heavens which are knotted into essence and are transformed into spirit which is then transformed into man.<sup>75</sup>

71 These are to be distinguished from actual lead and mercury used in chemical alchemy, as chemical alchemical and physiological alchemical terms are often used interchangeably; see Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, 22–4. On the ‘true’ (or vital) lead and mercury, see *ibid.*, 25, 49, 60, and *passim*.

72 Such a scheme of general correspondence is a concrete case of how the Five Phases system is applied in physiological alchemy; see Schipper, *Taoist Body*, 35.

73 *Laozi* 55: “He who has in himself abundant virtue is comparable to an infant” 含德之厚比於赤子, see Zhu Qianzhi, *Laozi jiaoshi*, 218.

74 See Schipper, *Taoist Body*, 119.

75 See Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 140–1.

These congenital knots, however, are also the “death-roots of the womb”, which plant a morbid breath into man. These germs of death must be ontologically cut off by breathing techniques. Thus, the alchemical process is to retrace “one’s steps along the road of bodily decay”<sup>76</sup> by forming an immortal embryo within, so as to ultimately replace the adept’s mortal body.

If the course of life and death is natural, would not reversing it be ‘unnatural’, violating an essential message of Daoism? Ji Kang’s “Treatise on Nourishing Life” strongly argues that the normal course of life is considered ‘natural’ only by “people of mediocre intelligence or less”.<sup>77</sup> The Daoist adept instead follows secret principles of nature unseen by common eyes. Su Shi does not make this statement explicitly, but he does agree, through quotation, that it is merely “human” to follow the natural course, while it is in the true Way to reverse it, echoing the argument in *Laozi*: “Returning is the movement of the Way” 反者道之動.<sup>78</sup> The Daoist thus claims to follow the esoteric rule of nature.

[2] A hermit taught me, “One shall sit upright, clench one’s fists and settle one’s mind. When the breath becomes quiet, slowly subdue it. (*Bodhidharma’s embryonic-respiration practice*’ also requires subduing the breath.<sup>79</sup> If one waits for it to stop by itself, as suggested in Buddhist sūtras, I am afraid that the mercury will not reach [the heart and the lungs].) Then, although one has nothing in mind, one feels tall and luminous, courageous and fierce, like a fire which cannot be attacked. When one breath exhausts, let the air penetrate slightly; with a quiet breath, subdue it again. (*When the air is about to penetrate, limit it to one breath; once this breath returns*,<sup>80</sup> it has already descended into the Cinnabar Field.) Do it. The more, the better; the longer, the greater you will accomplish. Within ten days, you shall feel the Cinnabar Field warm with water brimming upward. The longer you practise it, the warmer it feels, almost to the extent of boiling, swelling like a fountain, vegetating like clouds, steam-

76 Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, 25; also 130–5, and *passim*.

77 See Ji Kang, “Yangshenglun”, Dai Mingyang, *Ji Kang ji jiaozhu*, 3.152.

78 *Laozi*, ch. 40; see Zhu Qianzhi, *Laozi jiaoshi*, 165.

79 Embryonic respiration means to breathe through neither mouth nor nose, but through the navel, like a foetus in the womb; see Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, 145–6. “Bodhidharma’s embryonic-respiration practice” refers to a method prescribed in *Taixijing* 胎息經, which recommends “stopping the *qi*” 氣住. See Huanzhen xiansheng 幻真先生, *Taixijing zhu* 胎息經註, in *Daoxue jinghua* 道學精華, 129–31.

80 This refers to the believed circulation of the breath in the body, not the actual respiratory circulation as described in modern biology.

ing into your Mud Ball.<sup>81</sup> It is because *li* means ‘to adhere’;<sup>82</sup> as it is in the nature of things to catch fire once adhered [to fire]. My eyes are attracted to forms, my ears to sounds, my mouth to flavours, and my nose to fragrances, so that fire follows and adheres to them. Now if I rest in quietude without being attracted to anything external, there will be nothing for the fire to adhere to. Then where does the fire go? The water is its consort, so it will necessarily follow the water. *Kan* means ‘a hollow’. It is in the nature of water to receive things whenever they arrive, let alone being the consort of the fire. When water and fire unite, fire will not burn and water will naturally swell. This process is the so-called ‘the dragon comes out of fire’. When the dragon comes out of fire, the dragon will not fly, and the mercury will not exhaust. In just over ten days, your brain will be full and your waist and feet will feel light. When you practise breath control, constantly curl your tongue backward to lick your uvula. Even though it might not reach it, maintain the mindfulness, and eventually it will reach it. Keep practising, and the mercury [namely, saliva] will trickle into your mouth. When you practise breath control, rinse [the accumulated saliva] and turn it into steam; wait until it fills your mouth and then swallow it. (*If it is not yet full, keep it in your mouth and wait for the next cycle.*) Send it with hollowed breath into the lower Cinnabar Field and constantly nurture it in your mind. Longer, it will transform into lead. This is the so-called ‘in water the tiger is born.’”

有隱者教予曰：“人能正坐，瞑目調息，握固定心，息微則徐閉之。（達摩胎息法，亦須閉。若如佛經，待其自止，恐汞不能到也。）雖無所念，而卓然精明，毅然剛烈，如火之不可犯，息極則小通之，微則復閉之。（方其通時，亦限一息，一息歸之，已下丹田中也。）爲之。惟數以多爲賢，以久爲功，不過十日，則丹田溫而水上行，愈久愈溫，幾至如烹，上行如水，蓊然如雲，炁于泥丸。蓋離者，麗也，着物而見火之性也。吾目引於色，耳引於聲，口引於味，鼻引於香，火輒隨而麗之。今吾寂然無所引於外，火無所麗，則將焉往？水其所妃也，勢必從之。坎者，陷也，物至則受，水之性也，而況其妃乎？水火合，則火不炎而水自上，則所謂‘龍從火裏出’也。

81 Terminology referring to a brain cavity situated three inches behind the central space between the eyebrows. See Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 125.

82 In the *Book of Changes*, the trigram *li* 離 is explained as *li* 麗, that is, to ‘adhere to’, just like the sun and the moon ‘adhere’ to the sky, or the vegetation ‘adheres’ to the soil. See *Zhouyi zhengyi*, 3:31, SSJZS, 43.

龍出於火，則龍不飛，而汞不乾。旬日之外，腦滿而腰足輕，方閉息時，常卷舌而上，以舐懸癰，雖不能到，而意到焉，久則能到也。如是不已，則汞下入口。方調息時，則漱而烹之，須滿口而後嚥。（若未滿，且留口中，俟後次也。）仍以空氣送至下丹田，常以意養之，久則化而為鉛。此所謂‘虎向水中生’也。”

Here, an anonymous hermit came to transmit the occult science. What is curious, however, is the dearth of instructions. His message can be boiled down to two points: a practitioner shall subdue his breath and lick his uvula. Since it was a letter addressed to Su Che, it was hardly likely that Su Shi withheld information from his brother. Possibly, since Su Che was an experienced practitioner, he knew how to supplement the missing routines. This is why the only interlineal notes by Su Shi himself are in regard to breath control, saliva production, the debate of different techniques and suggestions of strategies. The rest, though ostensibly mystical and fabulous, requires no explanation to a selective, informed audience. More significant for the insiders are those deceptively simple tricks.

One point is made on whether to subdue (*bi* 閉) or to stop (*zhi* 止) the breath. According to Needham and Lu, pre-Tang respiratory control recommended holding the breath to the extent of stopping it, which might have resulted in unfortunate, even mortal, accidents. Thus, since the Tang, breathing became secondary to an imaginative voluntary circulation of *qi* through the internal organs, assisted by aerophagy (*fuqi* 服氣). The practitioner swallows air and forces its circulation in his intestinal tract, where it is supposed to be melted and recast.<sup>83</sup> Su's suggestion of swallowing saliva with “hollowed breath” into the abdomen must be a form of aerophagy.<sup>84</sup>

The method of licking the uvula to produce saliva is mentioned by the Daoist physician Sun Simiao 孫思邈 (581?–682?).<sup>85</sup> Saliva is precious nectar in physiological alchemy. It is variously called the ‘divine juice’ (*lingye* 靈液), ‘gold liquor’ (*jinli* 金醴), and ‘pure water of the jade pool’ (*yuchiqingshui* 玉池清水) in the *Yellow Court Scripture*. Saliva performs two complementary func-

83 See Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, 147–50.

84 Su Shi was acutely interested in breathing control techniques. He also wrote about this topic in “Li Ruozhi buqi” 李若之布氣, *SSWJ*, 73.2333–4; “Shiqi gong qishu” 侍其公氣術, *SSWJ*, 73.2334; “Yangshengjue” 養生訣, *SSWJ*, 73.2335–6; “Taixifa” 胎息法, *SSWJ*, 73.2337–8.

85 Sun quoted Xiang'er 想爾, the legendary immortal, who recommended, “Reverse your tongue into the throat, then rinse the trickle and swallow the saliva” 反舌塞喉漱漏咽液; see *Shenyang zhenzhongfang*, in Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, 737.

tions. The first is the rinsing of the mouth; the second is “the nourishment of immortality in the course of meditation”.<sup>86</sup> It is treated as the water-of-life which irrigates and moistens the body. Further, as Needham and Lu suggest, hyper-salivation makes air-swallowing easier. Salivary deglutition arose under the Tang, when aerophagy was added to breath-retention as part of breathing control practice.<sup>87</sup> Saliva, as liquid jade, is the *yin* part of the couple ‘jade-gold’.<sup>88</sup> After it is tempered in the furnace of the body, as Su Shi suggests, it will turn into lead, the *yang* or ‘gold’ element. The ‘true lead’ transformed from saliva is the tiger born in water.

This same “hermit” was very likely the “Daoist from over the seas” mentioned in a highly cryptic poem by Su Shi, written in 1096, called, “A Daoist from over the seas has taught me a mantra to guard my vital pneuma with spirit”.<sup>89</sup> This poem is possibly related to the “Discourse on the Dragon and the Tiger”. As discussed earlier, receiving an orally transmitted mantra is crucial for a Daoist adept. Without it, he may fumble among exoteric texts, oblivious to their true meaning. Writing compromises the esoteric nature of an oral transmission. Therefore, as a versified version of the oral teaching that Su received, this poem was very likely not intended to be understood, even though it slyly shares the secret.

[3] This theory is unusual yet reasonable, wondrous yet simple. Its credibility is beyond question. But I have a big problem. In my life I have made such oaths hundreds of times, all to no avail. In my opinion, this art cannot be accomplished unless one practises it with total devotion of the body, receives its teaching in one’s hollowed heart, and abides by its command until the end of one’s life. Now, I am already sixty, my reputation and career ruined, separated from my brother and sons, living in a barbaric country, with no prospect of returning north. The insipid flavour of this world – I know it all! I would not be man if I kept on neglecting this call. So, in the last few days, I have made an oath anew. Think of an ancient person who hid in a desolate mountain to escape havoc or was sent on a mission into remote territory, feeding upon grass or snow – how is it like to be such a man! I have ordered a meditation couch and two big

86 Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 90.

87 See Needham and Lu, *Spagyric Discovery*, 150–1.

88 See Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 90.

89 See Su Shi, “Haishangdaoren chuan yishenshouqi jue” 海上道人傳以神守氣訣, sssj, 40.2209–10. One reading of this esoteric poem is offered by Zhong Laiyin, *Su Shi*, 168–9. However, I am not convinced by Zhong’s interpretation.



desks to put under a bright window solely for this purpose. I have had a hundred cakes steamed and aired dry. From the first day of the second month on, I shall abjure all human affairs. Whenever I feel hungry, I will eat those cakes only, drink no soup or water and accept no other kinds of food. I shall chew slowly to nurture saliva and drink only a sparing amount of wine. After midday, I shall take a short nap. I shall lie at the first watch and rise at the third, sitting to watch for the dawn. When the sun rises, I shall gather the essence of the sun; when the moon rises, that of the moon. In the remaining time, I will either count my breath and temper the *yin* force within, or practise the dragon-and-tiger formula related above. If I do it for a hundred days, I might achieve something. I shall neither read nor write – put it aside for the future. I shall not excuse to mountains or rivers. I shall not receive any guest, or drink with people other than accomplished practitioners of the Way. All such things do me no good. But I fear deeply that my undisciplined nature will ultimately prohibit this oath from being fulfilled. So I write it down beforehand to let you know, so that I would not dare break this promise, lest I feel shameful in front of my own dear brother. But this matter is very difficult indeed! I do not know whether I might end up feeling ashamed after all. This letter thus intends both to strengthen my resolution and to inspire you, my brother.

此論奇而通，妙而簡，決爲可信者。然吾有大患，平生發此志願百十回矣，皆繆悠無成，意此道非捐軀以赴之，剗心以受之，盡命以守之，不能成也。吾今年已六十，名位破敗，兄弟隔絕，父子離散，身居蠻夷，北歸無日，區區世味，亦可知矣。若復繆悠於此，真不如人矣。故數日來，別發誓願。譬如古人避難窮山，或使絕域，齧草啖雪，彼何人哉！已令造一禪榻、兩大案，明牕之下，專欲治此。并已作乾蒸餅百枚。自二月一日爲首，盡絕人事。飢則食此餅，不飲湯水，不啖食物，細嚼以致津液，或飲少酒而已。午後，畧睡。一更便卧，三更乃起，坐以待旦。有日採日，有月採月，餘時非數息煉陰，則行今所謂龍虎訣爾。如此百日，或有所成。不讀書著文，且一時閑起，以待異日。不遊山水，除見道人外，不接客，不會飲，無益也。深恐易流之性，不能終踐此言，故先書以報，庶幾他日有慙於弟而不敢變也。此事大難，不知其果能不慙否？此書既以自堅，又欲以發弟也。

Su Shi's practice includes a dry-cake-and-wine diet, a rigorous schedule, gathering the cosmic essence, respiratory control and the dragon-and-tiger



physiological exercise. Saliva and wine are the only allowed sources of liquid. Wine is a crucial supplement in a Daoist diet. Su Shi related that his fellow practitioner, Wu Ziyé 吳子野, had undertaken a diet of eating nothing, but drinking a certain “Authentic One Wine” (*zhenyijiu* 真一酒), to aid the “Heaven-Made Drug” (*tianzaozhiyao* 天造之藥) formed through physiological alchemy.<sup>90</sup> Wine helps the circulation of blood and is thus perceived as a *yang* substance related to blood and semen, in contrast to saliva, a *yin* substance. Drinking them, and them alone, facilitates the practitioner to achieve the inner cosmic balance. Aside from the liquids, Su Shi proclaims he will eat only unflavoured dry cake, lest his appetite be aroused.<sup>91</sup> He repeatedly swears his absolute commitment, only to add a disclaimer towards the end; which begs the question: would he really succeed?

[4] Curling one's tongue to lick the uvula is a method that I recently learned. At first I rather cherished it and kept it secret. This is what the Chan teaching says, “The upward way cannot be imparted, even if you beg a thousand sages”. My understanding is truly laughable, but it is very effective. After a few days of practice, unfortunately, the tendon under my tongue has sharp pains. It needs to be domesticated first to perform this challenge. If the tip of my tongue can really reach the uvula, then it will be the fastest way to fetch water from the Blossom Pond.<sup>92</sup> [The Daoist] also said, “This method is called ‘a patch of snow above a melting stove’”. Keep it a secret at least for now.

卷舌以舐懸癰，近得此法，初甚秘惜之。此禪家所謂“向上一路子，千聖不傳人”，所見如此，雖可笑，然極有驗也。但行之數日間，舌下筋急痛，當以漸馴致。若舌尖果能及懸癰，則致華池之水，莫捷於此也。又言：“此法名‘烘爐上一點雪’。”宜且秘之。

The last passage appears too jovial to be serious. Immortality would have been achieved were it not for a banal hardship: an untamed tongue. Yet the poet

90 See Su Shi, “Zhenyijiu ge” 真一酒歌, *SSSJ*, 43.2359–62.

91 On the harm of flavoured food, see *Taiqing huangting zhongjing* 太清黃庭中經, in Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, 339.

92 Another term for the mouth, or the “Jade Pond” (*yuchi* 玉池). It acquired this name because the Daoist practitioner used his tongue to stir the saliva that had accumulated below his tongue until foam had formed; he then had to swallow the foam. The white foam is thus compared to “jade” or “blossom”. See *Shangqing huangting neijing jing* 上清黃庭內景經, in Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, 284–5.

pleads his brother, and all the future readers, to keep the secret, while he is revealing it in indelible, written words.

Su Shi was fond of scribbling down the secrets of longevity. To what extent he practised these methods remains doubtful. He seemed to lack faith in his perseverance. In another letter to Su Che, he similarly relates a few newly learned methods. Yet the true purpose is to adjure Che, the quiet and resolute one, to become an immortal first, so that Su Shi might become an immortal by association.<sup>93</sup> It rings of political sarcasm, since Su Che was banished because of his association with Su Shi. According to Huang Tingjian, though Su Shi was always fascinated by the Daoist art, he could never abide by a certain prescription for a long period of time; a certain 'Daoist from over the seas' called him a "banished immortal".<sup>94</sup> Huang's colophon raises the likelihood that the same Daoist transmitted his secret to Su because of Su's destined candidacy for immortality. It may also explain why his method is so emphatically simple: it was designed for the distracted Su Shi to follow. Yet even so, judging from his self-diagnosis (not to mention the Spartan diet), the reader has good reason to suspect Su's failure.

This discourse is written in a private voice, which is all the more remarkable when compared to "A Sequel to the 'Treatise of Nourishing Life'" (Xu yangsheng lun 續養生論),<sup>95</sup> homage to Ji Kang's aforementioned treatise. The treatise shares the same theoretical framework as Ji's discourse and, at times, repeats it verbatim. But the private voice is replaced by a public one, featuring elaborated theoretical constructions and canonical quotations. The "Sequel" mentions neither Su's personal commitment or self-doubt, nor the highly technical details. The second treatise, in short, is exoteric and written for the public.

Could the private voice also be a disguise? A joke sometimes hides earnestness. Su Shi's resolve to become an 'earthly immortal' is confided in a letter written to his fellow practitioner Wang Dingguo. It declares:

Single-mindedly, I hold on to the doctrines of 'abstaining from study and having no worries', 'returning to the root', and 'guarding the One'.<sup>96</sup> Only then there is no such One to guard. Other than this is nothing but illusion. Please do not think this devotion dubious and remote. If I can indeed practise it, I shall see daily gains. Even at its most useless I shall at

93 See Su Shi, "Ji Ziyou sanfa" 寄子由三法, *SSWJ*, 73.2339.

94 See Huang Tingjian, "Ti Dongpo shu daoshu hou", 25.646.

95 See Su Shi, "Xu yangsheng lun", *SSWJ*, 64.1983–5.

96 Quotations from *Laozi*, 20, 16 and 10; Zhu Qianzhi, *Laozi jiaoshi*, 76, 65 and 37.

least become an Earth-roaming immortal. It is only that I must humiliate myself to live a dog's life [literally, "crawl through a dog's hole"]. Please do not tell anyone else. I only want you, my dear friend, to understand me.

某一味絕學無憂，歸根守一，乃無一可守。此外皆是幻。此道勿謂渺漫，信能如此，日有所得，更做沒用處，亦須作地行仙，但屈滯從狗竇中過爾。勿說與人，但欲老弟知其略爾。<sup>97</sup>

The "dog's life", as suggested elsewhere,<sup>98</sup> includes starvation, dining upon raw plants, and abstention from all sensual pleasures. It invites ridicule from those who hold the pursuit of immortality in contempt. Nevertheless, Su Shi is willing to endure these material and mental sufferings for his own good – a secret resolution confided only to family and friends.

### The Daoist on White Crane Peak

In Huizhou, Su Shi was not in charge of his life. When he first arrived, the local magistrate hosted him in Hejiang Tower 合江樓, a guesthouse that usually welcomed commissioners from the central court. Since accommodating an exile there was a possible transgression, a week later Su moved into Jiayou Temple 嘉祐寺, a secluded location on the eastern bank of the Western Riverlet.<sup>99</sup> His wellbeing had substantially improved since Cheng Zhicai's arrival and, within half a month, Su moved back into the Tower. In early 1096, Cheng was abruptly recalled, possibly because news of their repaired family ties had reached the court. As a consequence, Su Shi moved back into the Jiayou Temple.

Su Shi's housing options reflected alternative interpretations of his worth: as a fallen genius or a condemned criminal. To take his fate into his own hands, after the New Year of 1096, Su Shi began to build a house on a deserted Daoist temple compound on White Crane Peak 白鶴峰 at Mt Luofu,<sup>100</sup> where Ge Hong became an immortal. Su Shi's meaningful choice showed a desire to transcend the various interpretations of his identity that had been externally forced upon him. A poem, written after construction had begun, envisions a

97 Su Shi, "Yu Wang Dingguo sishiyishou", no. 41, *SSWJ*, 52.1531.

98 See Su Shi, "Anqisheng" 安期生, *SSSJ*, 43.2349–50.

99 For the account of Su's life in Huizhou, here and below, see *SSNP*, 33.1178–245.

100 See Su Shi, "Xinnian wushou" 新年五首, *SSSJ*, 40.2181–3.

life above the clouds and above the worldly imbroglio.<sup>101</sup> By early 1097, his villa on White Crane Peak was finished. He planted fruit trees, sent for his other sons, and was ready to spend the rest of his life there *à la* Ge Hong. He expressed this wish in a liturgical text written for the ‘installing the beams’ (*shangliang* 上梁) ceremony, which celebrates the completion of the house.<sup>102</sup>

[1] The myriad households of Goose City<sup>103</sup> are scattered at the crossing of two rivers; the lonely peak of White Crane Temple stands above a thousand cliffs. Mirage Mountains float in the ocean like phantasms. Immortals and transcendents soar into the sky in constant traffic. In olden times there was a solemn temple called a blessed place. It nourished lush greens and became a foxes’ den. Things prosper and decline; at times they appear or hide. Banished ten thousand *li* to the south, Master Dongpo has been hosted here for three years. He has no intention of returning and even plans to die here. He has mountains crossed and trees cut; he has come to the north against the river. In his neighbourhood is an ancient town, surrounded by crenellated walls and facing the peak from the south. His gaze sends off returning sails until the end of the horizon; a falling moon hangs ahead of his couch. He is about to open the Ink Pond of Yishao<sup>104</sup> and to set up the cinnabar stove of Zhichuan. After a thousand years away from home, he has finally returned together with Ding Lingwei.<sup>105</sup> Having a house the size of a single furrow, he idly records this residence of Yang Xiong. Now with the hundred walls erected,<sup>106</sup> he rides a carriage to arrive at the pair of front gate columns. Clerics and laymen all observe this occasion, and the whole village comes to his aid. He wishes to feast these respectful elders upon chicken and pork in this rural banquet; he forbids children to harass the neighbours’ geese or ducks. How could you decline the joy of a single bout of laughter? Let us tie the bond of eternal pleasure!

101 Su Shi, “Qianju” 遷居, *SSSJ*, 40.2194–6.

102 Su Shi, “Baihe xinju shangliangwen” 白鶴新居上梁文, *SSWJ*, 64.1989–90.

103 Aka. Huizhou, namesake of a Flying Goose Mountain (Fei’eling 飛鵝嶺) that fringes the southwest of the city, strategically the highest point of the urban area.

104 Aka. Wang Xizhi. See ch. 2, fn. 17.

105 According to *Soushen houji* 搜神後記, Ding Lingwei 丁令威 was a legendary Daoist who transformed into a crane and went home. See *Soushen houji* 搜神後記, ed. Wang Shaoying 汪紹楹 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1981), 1.1.

106 The term “a hundred walls” 百堵 comes from the Ode “Hongyan” 鴻雁 (Mao 181); see *Maoshi zhengyi*, 11.163, *SSJZS*, 431.

鵝城萬室，錯居二水之間；鶴觀一峯，獨立千巖之上。海山浮動而出沒，仙聖飛騰而往來。古有齋宮，號稱福地。鞠爲茂草，奄宅狐狸。物有廢興，時而隱顯。東坡先生，南遷萬里，僑寓三年。不起歸歟之心，更作終焉之計。越山斬木，泝江水以北來；古邑爲鄰，遶牙牆而南峙。送歸帆於天末，掛落月於床頭。方將開逸少之墨池，安稚川之丹竈。去家千歲，終同丁令之來歸；有宅一區，聊記揚雄之住處。今者既興百堵，爰駕兩楹。道俗來觀，里閭助作。願同父老，宴鄉社之雞豚；已戒兒童，惱比鄰之鵝鴨。何辭一笑之樂，永結無窮之歡。

The opening lines depict the singularity of White Crane villa, its imposing location symbolising transcendence and eternity. The vicissitude of things on this ground is a metaphor for the poet's fate, at times *yinxian* 隱顯 (meaning 'to hide or appear', or 'to retreat or prosper'). Banished to the Far South, Su Shi had fallen from grace (*xian*) to humiliation (*yin*). And through another transformation he changed from a hapless exile into a self-sufficient Daoist hermit. What he retained from his former identity is that of a man of letters, symbolised by the comparison of his house to that of Wang Xizhi, the calligrapher, and of Yang Xiong, the classicist. The second reference alludes to Su's writing of a commentary on the *Book of Changes* during this period. Otherwise, he is a would-be immortal who 'returned' by transforming himself into a crane. At the end of the paragraph, the ex-bureaucrat, poet and would-be immortal disguises himself in the role of a farmer-recluse. Like another Tao Qian, he hosts a banquet and toasts farmers from his neighbourhood. The text then turns lyrical:

[2] My good boys! Throw [the grains] to the east of the beams! Where the tall trees grow into the sky used to be a Buddhist or Daoist temple. Men all say – the master sleeps soundly in the spring; strike lightly the fifth-watch, ringer of the temple bell!

My good boys! Throw [the grains] to the west of the beams! A slender rainbow bridge rides across an emerald river. When the magistrate at times comes to ask for the Way, lantern lights scatter along the long bank till the depth of night.

My good boys! Throw [the grains] to the south of the beams! Ancient trees on the south riverbank cast shades on a swirling pond. Everyone laughs at the grey-haired master, who is planting in person two orange trees to the south of the house.

My good boys! Throw [the grains] to the north of the beams! Reflections of the mountains sway upon the north river waves. The master builds in person a fishing terrace. For a whole day he entertains himself with the water, never enough.

My good boys! Throw [the grains] above the beams! The jade-like moon and pearl-like stars shine upon a canopy of orchids. Next year the master will again build a Terrace of Gazing at the Immortals. The misty empty mountains form a gate for the retinue of clouds.

My good boys! Throw [the grains] below the beams! A well is dug, the vegetable garden ploughed, and the neighbourhood banquet now dispersed. Thousand-year-old wolfberry dogs wail long at night. On the cinabar ladder stretching into the sky, who is being transformed into a feathered one?

兒郎偉，拋梁東。喬木參天梵釋宮。盡道先生春睡美，道人輕打五更鐘。

兒郎偉，拋梁西。嫋嫋虹橋跨碧溪。時有使君來問道，夜深燈火亂長堤。

兒郎偉，拋梁南。南江古木蔭回潭。共笑先生垂白髮，舍南親種兩株柑。

兒郎偉，拋梁北。北江江水搖山麓。先生親築釣魚臺，終朝弄水何曾足。

兒郎偉，拋梁上。璧月珠星臨蕙帳。明年更起望仙臺，縹緲空山隘雲仗。

兒郎偉，拋梁下。鑿井疏畦散鄰社。千年枸杞夜長號，萬丈丹梯誰羽化。

Liturgical texts for the ‘installing the beam’ ritual, as found in some other Song anthologies, generally follow the same formula: beginning with a prose narrative of the construction of the building, followed by verses that begin with the trisyllabic incantation of a direction, either with or without the phrase *erliangwei* 兒郎偉 (‘My good boys!’), and ending with prose prayers for auspiciousness. In the repetitive opening line(s) of each stanza, the only variant is the character for the six directions, vertical and horizontal, representing the whole

cosmos. The word for the direction also fixes the rhyme for each stanza. This liturgical formula might well be accompanied by the actual action of children throwing agricultural produce in each direction of the beams. The rest of the stanza is heptasyllabic, rhyming at the end of the third and the fifth lines. In Su Shi's composition, every third line describes the auspicious environment of the villa. The last two lines, notably, encode the gist of the message of each stanza.

In the first stanza, the ending couplet depicts a 'master' in contented sleep. He is well respected, as the narrative voice urges the temple bell-ringer not to disturb him by announcing the time. This image models itself on the iconic, timeless sleep of Chen Tuan 陳搏 (?–989), the Daoist master at Paramount Hua, who sometimes slept for months, leaving the emperors' envoy to wait in vain.<sup>107</sup> His negligence of time suggests his externality and, by the same token, he became an advisor to the throne without subjecting himself to the imperial power. Su Shi imagines himself another Chen Tuan, as in the second stanza the local magistrate comes to ask for the Way of governance. Stanzas three to five depict a series of planting and building projects. His undertakings are encoded. The orange tree is alternatively called 'wooden slave' (*munu* 木奴). Li Heng 李衡 (third century), Magistrate of Danyang 丹陽 (in modern Jiangsu Province), left a thousand 'wooden slaves' to his sons to provide for their livelihood and ensure their economic independence.<sup>108</sup> Su Shi's planting of two orange trees signifies a similar wish for material independence from official salary or charity. His next step is to build a fishing terrace. Holding a fishing pole symbolises both longing for and resistance to imperial power. Historical examples include many would-be advisors to the throne.<sup>109</sup> The angling fisherman does not seek to catch the 'fish', namely imperial recognition, but instead waits patiently for it to come to the 'bait', namely his virtue and infinite potential in governance. If the fish does not come, Su, the self-sufficient fisherman, is fine with that too. He will build a Terrace of Gazing at the Immortals and will then depart with the retinue of clouds into the empty mountains.

In the last stanza, the poet, while playing the role of an amiable neighbour, watches himself changing into a "feathered one" on a long ladder of life (sym-

107 Chen Tuan's legendary sleep was a popular theme among Su Shi's contemporaries. The first extensive account appeared in Zhang Fangping 張方平 (1007–1091), "Huashan chongxiu Yuntaiguan ji" 華山重修雲臺觀記, *Lequan ji* 樂全集, SKQS, 1104.33.11–5.

108 As recorded in Xi Zaochi's 習鑿齒 *Xiangyang ji* 襄陽記, quoted by Pei Songzhi 裴松之, in Chen Shou 陳壽, *Sanguo zhi* 三國志 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1959), 48.1156–7.

109 Famous examples include Lü Shang 呂尚 (eleventh century BCE), the founding minister of the Zhou Dynasty (see "Qi Taigong shijia" 齊太公世家, Sima Qian, *Shiji*, 32.1477–8), and Yan Guang 嚴光 (first century CE), recluse and friend of the first Eastern Han emperor (see "Yimin liezhuan" 逸民列傳, Fan Ye 范曄, *Houhanshu* 後漢書 [Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1965], 2763–4).



bolised by the cinnabar), stretching into the night sky. The spectator is none other than a wolfberry-dog.<sup>110</sup> This miraculous dog is itself transformed from the root of a thousand-year-old wolfberry. It lives in the Cave of Vermilion Light,<sup>111</sup> not far from Su's villa, and now, in the small hours of the day, sees his silent transformation.

[3] I pray, after the installation of beams, that crops shall grow every year on the mountains and no hurricane shall rise above the ocean. The air shall be dry and clear; my family healthy; and there will be no need for Dr. Chen's drug. The harvest shall be big; the rice be cheap; and I can buy on credit Auntie Lin's wine. Whoever associates with me shall increase fortune and longevity.

伏願上梁之後，山有宿麥，海無颶風。氣爽人安，陳公之藥不散；年豐米賤，林婆之酒可賒。凡我往還，同增福壽。

At the end of the liturgical text, Su again plays the good farmer-recluse. He has no other wish than the health of his family and the fortune of his associates. What is left unsaid is that he has always been a curse in others' lives – his long-term companion, Zhaoyun 朝雲 (1062–1095), has just died of miasma and his family and friends are still victims of his downfall. Now, he wishes no more suffering, so that he can take leave with peace of mind.

In this light-hearted text, the poet envisions himself enjoying a certain 'alterity', displaying multiple identities in varying contexts. Among the villagers, he is an amiable neighbour. With the local magistrates, he is a high-minded counsellor in hiding. Yet, at the end of the day, he is the immortal climbing a cinnabar ladder into another realm of existence.

The construction of the villa at White Crane Peak culminated Su's transformation of his identity into a Daoist alchemist and recluse. Only two months later, however, Su was further banished to Hainan. His reading of destiny proved wrong.

<sup>110</sup> See ch. 4, fn. 122.

<sup>111</sup> The Cave of Vermilion Light, said to be a grotto heaven, is located behind Chongxu Temple 沖虛觀 where Ge Hong once lived. Allegedly, the roots of ancient wolfberry trees growing in the hidden depths of this cave had changed into miraculous canines that sometimes barked at night. See Su Shi, "Ciyun Zhengfu you Baishuishan" 次韻正輔同游白水山, *SSSJ*, 39:2148–50.

### Retreat from Nature

If the legend was true, Su Shi's jovial couplet, "Men all say – the master sleeps soundly in the spring; strike lightly the fifth-watch, ringer of the temple bell", stirred great ire in the heart of his learned enemy, Chancellor Zhang Dun. To deprive Su of such ease, Zhang banished Su even farther to Danzhou. It was presumably a diabolic *jeu de mots*: the character *dan* 儋 shares the same phonetic with *zhan* 瞻, as in Su Shi's polite name Zizhan 子瞻. Legend further has it that Zhang Dun was exacting revenge for Su Shi's ridiculing of his mentor Wang Anshi's etymological interpretation of the classics.<sup>112</sup>

This story is fantastical, but not implausible. For men who lived in texts, life was comprehensible only in reference. After all, the same could be said of Su Shi: he perceived Mt Luofu as his destined locus of transcendence only because of the precedence of Ge Hong, author of *Baopuzi*, a work itself deeply embedded in a shared textual tradition. Mesmerised by the textual references encoded in the name Luofu, Su Shi derived a reading of his fate – a reading that proved wrong because of Zhang Dun's reading of a text which encoded Su's reading of fate.

His forced departure from Huizhou seemed to be disillusioning. Su Shi realised that he was not predestined to die – or 'undie' – on White Crane Peak after all. Even if he did not lose faith in the Daoist art *per se*, he no longer believed in his own chance of transcendence, as revealed in his Hainan poems.<sup>113</sup> His change of mind is summarily represented in the "Rhapsody on the Milky Spring of the Tianqing Temple" (Tianqingguan ruquan fu 天慶觀乳泉賦),<sup>114</sup> written in 1098 and held by himself to be his best composition at Hainan.<sup>115</sup> In this text, he first expatiates on a general theory of water as the source of vitality. According to him, all water could be dichotomised into 'sweet' (*gan* 甘) and 'salty' (*xian* 鹹), each associated respectively with vitality and death. Corporeal

112 See Zeng Jili, *Tingzhai shihua*, 66–7. This story is recorded in slightly different versions in Lu You, *Laoxuean biji*, 4.50, as well as in Luo Dajing 羅大經, *Helinyulu* 鶴林玉露 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1983), *bingbian* 丙編, 5.315, two usually reliable works. Even if there was not necessarily an actual plot, Zhang Dun's desire to see Su Shi's death was perhaps real enough. As a poem by Huang Tingjian states, "When Zizhan was banished to the South of the Dayu Ridge, then Chancellor wanted to see him dead" 子瞻謫嶺南，時宰欲殺之； see "Ba Zizhan 'He Tao shi'" 跋子瞻和陶詩, *Huang Tingjian quanji*, 17.604.

113 Ronald Egan has translated some of them: see Egan, *Word, Image, and Deed*, 244–5. Yet, without seeing the transition in Su Shi's belief, Egan wrongly understands Su Shi's self-doubt as his doubt of the pursuit of longevity (especially Ge Hong's pursuit) *per se*.

114 Su Shi, "Tianqingguan ruquan fu", *SSWJ*, 1.15–6.

115 See Fei Gun, *Liangxi manzhi*, 4.7.

liquids, including sweat, tears, urine and blood, are all salty; they represent material forms of the death essence which tends to depart the human body. Only the “true liquid of the Blossom Pond”, namely, saliva, is sweet and is the original drug of immortality. The cosmic sweet water circulates in the forms of rain, dew, frost and snow, and accumulates in rivers, lakes, wells and springs. In this perpetual cycle of transformation, water is eternal and inexhaustible, and so is vitality. Seawater and salty springs, on the other hand, are the accumulated death essence of the cosmos; these kill and do not nourish life. After relating this general theory, Su Shi described his nocturnal excursion to a sweet spring in a Daoist temple – the source of immortal life.

Since I was banished to live in Dan'er,<sup>116</sup> I divined a construction spot to the south of the city wall, next to the temple of the God of Fate. All the local wells are salty, except one spring, sweet like ale and milk surging from within the temple. It provides for my cooking, drinking and making of wine and tea. How abundant and inexhaustible! Once I rose in the middle of the night, took a drinking jar and went east. Only the setting moon followed me – no human companions.

The water-fetcher did not stir and the cosmic air of the night just began to retreat. The spring clanged like jade pendants falling into a valley. The jade pond, scintillating, gave birth to rich foams.<sup>117</sup> I gulped thrice and returned immediately, afraid to be chided by guardian gods. I shall abjure the five flavours<sup>118</sup> to decline the six kinds of dust.<sup>119</sup> When I realise the one single truth, I shall shed all the hundred misdeeds. I believe in an elixir that leads to immortality. But nothing presides deep within me, so

116 Aka. Danzhou; a name that refers to its ancient people's purported ethnographic feature of having huge ear lobes.

117 “In the jade pond, pure water gives birth to rich foam” 玉池清水上生肥. The “jade pond” refers to the mouth; “pure water” refers to pure saliva. The practitioner should use his tongue to stir saliva pooled below the tongue until foam is formed, then swallow the foam. See *Shangqing huangting neijing jing*, Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, ch. 29, 285; cf. *ibid.*, 272.

118 Referring to food which tastes sour, bitter, sweet, spicy or salty. See *Zhonghua daoqiao dacidian* 中華道教大辭典, ed. Hu Fuchen 胡孚琛 (Beijing: Zhongguo shehuikexue chubanshe, 1995), 472.

119 Referring to six kinds of worldly desires which cloud one's authentic nature. The concrete numeration differs. One definition suggests that these are the dusted six ‘roots’, i.e. eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body and mind. Another definition lists wealth, lust, fame, gluttony, sleep and laxity. A third theory lists lust, music, fragrance, taste, touch and dharma. See Hu Fuchen, *Zhonghua daoqiao dacidian*, 472.

what can I depend upon? Alas, Master Scarlet Pine, Prince Qiao, where art thou? Let my imagination, let my fantasy, to capture thee!

吾謫居儋耳，卜築城南，隣於司命之宮，百井皆鹹，而醪醴渾乳，獨發於宮中，給吾飲食酒茗之用，蓋沛然而無窮。吾嘗中夜而起，挈甌而東。有落月之相隨，無一人而我同。

汲者未動，夜氣方歸。鏘瓊佩之落谷，灑玉池之生肥。吾三咽而遄返，懼守神之訶譏。却五味以謝六塵，悟一真而失百非。信飛仙之有藥，中無主而何依。渺松喬之安在，猶想像於庶幾。

At daytime, this spring displays an appearance of deceptive normalcy: it supplies the local households with their daily water. Yet, this sole fresh-water source is located nowhere else than in the palace of the God of Fate. The deeply meaningful location associates the spring to the realm of fate and transcendence.

The poet does not explain what made him restless at midnight and drove him on this nocturnal excursion. He might have been either unable to sleep or practising meditation. In any case, he seems to be possessed by mystic inspiration. He finds the spring refreshing; the spring itself at the cosmic moment of night changing slowly into day, a moment symbolised and strengthened by the change of rhyme (marked by the paragraph break in my translation). He calls it a “jade pond”, a physiological alchemical term which relates the spring water to saliva, a source of vitality. But the devoted adept feels uneasy in the suspected presence of the “guardian gods”. He takes three – a symbolic number for triadic unity – gulps of water and immediately returns, as if having violated a territory he had no right to enter. Despite his belief in the drug of immortality, he wonders if he is ready to take it. To receive the drug, he needs something “presiding” (*zhu* 主) inside. This presiding force might refer to a spiritual embryo (*lingtai* 靈胎) formed through physiological alchemy. Transcendence is achieved only when an “embryo of the subtle and immortal body” is formed to replace the adept’s gross body.<sup>120</sup> Without this fully formed embryo, the adept can only fantasise about the realm of divinity.

The structure of adventure into, and immediate retreat from, a transcendental realm also appears in the “Latter Rhapsody on the Red Cliff” (Hou Chibi fu 後赤壁賦), written in the late fall of 1082, during his exile in Huangzhou.<sup>121</sup> In the widely celebrated “Former Rhapsody on the Red Cliff” (Qian Chibi fu 前

120 See Robinet, *Taoist Meditation*, 89.

121 Translated and discussed in Egan, *Word, Image, and Deed*, 245–49.

赤壁賦), composed three months earlier, Su Shi declares that he shall transcend the fear of mortality by entrusting himself to the cosmic cycle of change, since the distinction between the eternity of the universe and the transience of individual life is illusory, relative to perspective.<sup>122</sup> However, in the less-acclaimed “Latter Rhapsody”, which also depicts a nocturnal boat excursion to the Red Cliff with two unnamed guests, Su Shi is driven by restlessness. He climbs the cliff alone, ventures into the realm of powerful creatures and heaves a long whistle at the top of the cliff. Nature responds with resounding echoes and surging wind and waves. Feeling a sudden chill, the poet retreats in fear. When he is back in the boat, a lone crane soars over his head and emits a loud and long shriek. That night, Su Shi dreams of a Daoist (who refuses to reveal his name) in a feathered robe, asking him, “Was the excursion to the Red Cliff delightful?”. In response to Su Shi’s question of whether he was the crane, the Daoist smiles and disappears, leaving the poet to wake with a pounding heart.<sup>123</sup>

The tone of optimistic abandon in the “Former Rhapsody” disappears from the “Latter Rhapsody”. The poet’s enchanted climb sets him apart from his two guests, who are incapable of leaving the security of the boat – an artificial haven. He sees tigers, leopards, dragons and falcons in their true forms at night, dangerous but indifferent to his existence. He even peeps into the hidden palace of Pingyi 馮夷, the River God. Yet, in the neighbourhood of divinity, the poet only feels his own alienness – his unbelonging. He retreats abruptly with awe and fear. The crane, incarnated as the feathered Daoist in his dream, is a signal sent by this transcendental realm. But its intention is ambivalent. The long shriek may be either to beckon or to warn. And, if the poet in the “Latter Rhapsody” still cherishes the hope of having been beckoned by the transcendental, the poet in the Tianqing Temple has now entirely lost such hope. His fetching of the primordial water appears to him a hasty theft, one that risks the chiding of guardian gods.

As the last line of the “Rhapsody on the Milky Spring” suggests, he may not achieve the ultimate freedom, represented by immortals like Scarlet Pine or Prince Qiao. Nevertheless, his freedom is secured in creative imagination, which literally takes flight in the form of spiritual roaming. He retreats, therefore, from nature into an inner cosmos – even though this freedom is conditioned by his physicality. In a cryptic poem written one restless night, Su Shi tries to pacify his anxiety over mortality:

故山不可到  
飛夢隔五嶺

The hometown mountains cannot be reached –  
my flying dream is obstructed by the Five Ranges.

122 Su Shi, “Qian Chibi fu” 前赤壁賦, *sswJ*, 1.6.

123 Su Shi, “Hou Chibi fu” 後赤壁賦, *sswJ*, 1.8.

真遊有黃庭  
閉目寓兩景

The true roaming is within the Yellow Court;  
when eyes are closed, the sun and the moon are  
locked within.<sup>124</sup>

室空無可照

But the chamber is empty – there is nothing to  
illuminate;

火滅膏自冷

when the flame burns out, the grease will naturally  
chill.<sup>125</sup>

披衣起視夜  
海闊河漢永  
西窗半明月  
散亂梧楸影

I throw on a robe, rise up and look into the night –  
the ocean is vast; the Milky Way, eternal.  
The western window is lit by a bright half-moon;  
dispersed are the shadows of phoenix and catalpa  
trees.

良辰不可繫  
逝水無由騁  
我苗期後枯  
持此一念靜

This beautiful moment cannot be detained,  
just like the bygone water will not flow again.  
I expect only that my seedling will wither a little later;  
holding this single thought, my mind becomes  
tranquil.<sup>126</sup>

This poem begins with images of distance and obstruction. His dream is concretised as a flying bird, but its wings are not powerful enough to flap across the mountain ranges separating the southern regions from the central plains. When physical ‘return’ cannot be accomplished, the poet resorts instead to pure meditation within the “Yellow Court” as a form of true roaming. Once in this inner cosmos, however, Su realises that his inner chamber is empty – perhaps suggesting again that his ‘spiritual embryo’ has not been formed as yet. He is running out of time: his fire of life is dying and his flesh chilling. His fear of mortality cannot be dissuaded by philosophy, and the poet is disquieted. The vast ocean and eternal Milky Way signify constancy, but the sinking half-moon and dispersed shadows symbolise his waning hours and draining vitality. The beauty of the present moment is incessantly fading into the past. After denouncing the power of mental reality, Su Shi, in the small hours of the night, concludes that he should try to nourish his physical wellbeing, without which nothing can be helped. The penultimate line refers to the aforementioned

124 Namely, the two eyes. In Daoist meditation practice, when the eyes (the left eye is the sun, the right eye is the moon) are closed, the adept shall imagine the sun and the moon shining through his “inner landscape” (*neijing* 內景), that is, his internal organs. See *Shangqing huangting neijing jing*, in Zhang Junfang, *Yunji qiqian*, 200–1. For a detailed description of this inner landscape, see Schipper, *Taoist Body*, 105–08.

125 The “flame” refers to vital energy, while the “grease” refers to the flesh.

126 Su Shi, “He Tao ‘Zashi’ shiyishou” 和陶雜詩十一首, no. 2, *SSSJ*, 41.2273.

'crop' analogy in Ji Kang's treatise. Though death is the ultimate call, it is a moral command for man to prolong life as much as he can, just like a farmer must keep tending his crops despite the cosmic drought. When the crop finally withers, at least the farmer feels at peace.

### Active Immersion in Transience

Now that the aged poet was convinced of his mortality, the existential angst could only be alleviated by living in the constant transience. Su Shi in Hainan suffered from deprivation and ill health. The past could not be saved; destiny could not be calculated. The spiritual spontaneity of living in transience was, for him, not a philosophical catchphrase but a survival strategy.

This sentiment permeates many of Su Shi's writings at Hainan and is best articulated in a triad of poems matching Tao Qian's allegorical "Form, Reflection and Spirit" (Xing ying shen 形影神), a set of three poems which imagine the versified dialogue among the three aspects of human existence. In Tao's poems, Form laments its mortality. Reflection, pointing out that the wish for immortality is vain given the extreme challenge of the task, proposes that the only thing remaining after death is one's good deeds. Each speech ends with the gesture of offering a toast with a cup of wine. Spirit offers to appease their anxiety by arguing that not even good deeds matter. Everything is over when one dies, but there shall be no fear – since this is the natural course of things.<sup>127</sup> Su Shi admired Tao's philosophical equanimity, despite his own ambivalence. In his matching poems, he offered three sophisticated approaches to the question of death. Form represents the physical aspect of human existence. From its point of view, the greatest fear in life is the unknown, which often assumes a metaphysical dimension. Death is the ultimate unknown. The only certainty is the precise correspondence between physical existence and its own "reflection".<sup>128</sup> Reflection represents the world's perception of an individual's existence. Any action has its consequence on one's perceived image, which, like a reflection in a mirror, does not vanish even when the mirror is smashed.

127 Tao Qian, "Xing ying shen" 形影神, *TYM*, 2.67. David Hawkes interpreted these three poems to represent respectively the perspective of religious Daoism, Confucianism and Zhuangzian Daoism (or Heavenly Teacher sect); see David Hawkes, *The Poetry of Tao Ch'ien* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1970), 44–5. He translated the title as "Substance, Shadow and Spirit". I choose to translate it as "Form, Reflection and Spirit", since this set of terms works better for Su Shi's argument.

128 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Xing zeng ying'" 和陶形贈影, *SSSJ*, 42.2306.



Its response raises the doctrine of non-duality. It suggests that active cognitive capacity (being awake) or the lack thereof (being drunk) does not make a difference in a dream world – a world of illusions.<sup>129</sup> At last, the Spirit comes to offer its solution.<sup>130</sup>

二子本無我  
其初因物著  
豈惟老變衰  
念念不如故  
知君非金石  
安得長託附  
莫從老君言  
亦莫用佛語  
仙山與佛國  
終恐無是處  
甚欲隨陶翁  
移家酒中住  
醉醒要有盡

未易逃諸數  
平生逐兒戲  
處處餘作具  
所至人聚觀  
指目生毀譽  
如今一弄火  
好惡都焚去  
既無負載勞  
又無寇攘懼  
仲尼晚乃覺  
天下何思慮

The two gentlemen had no ultimate selves,  
but assumed their forms by adhering to things.  
Is it only because of the decrepitude of age,  
that with every single thought your state deteriorates?  
Knowing that you are unlike metal or stone,  
how can I consign myself long to you?  
Please don't follow the words of Lord Lao;  
nor use the Buddha's talk.  
The immortals' mountain or the Buddha's Land,  
for me there is none, I fear!  
My heart desires to follow the old man Tao –  
move the household to the land of wine!  
But being drunken or awake, either state comes to an  
end;  
there is no easy escape from one's fate.  
All my life is like chasing a child's play,  
leaving playthings wherever I stay.  
Everywhere I go, people gather to watch me;  
pointing or eyeing they blame or praise me.  
Now in a single feat of fire,  
fondness or disgust are both burnt.  
There remains no more ado to load or carry,  
nor any fear of inroad or robbery.  
Confucius realised this point only late –  
what thought or worry is there in All-under-Heaven?<sup>131</sup>

Ironically, Spirit, as the thinking faculty of man, concludes that its own abdication alone promises happiness. It sees no material vehicle as permanent. Even the Reflection, as trace of one's existence in the world, relies on material

129 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Ying da xing'" 和陶影答形, *SSSJ*, 42.2307.

130 Su Shi, "He Tao 'Shen shi'" 和陶神釋, *SSSJ*, 42.2307–8. Ronald Egan has offered a partial translation of the poem: Egan, *Word, Image, and Deed*, 245.

131 In the "Xicixia" 繫辭下 chapter in the *Book of Changes*, the Master says, "What thought or worry is there in All-under-Heaven?" 天下何思何慮. See *Zhouyi zhengyi*, 8.75, *SSJZS*, 87.

vehicles for its perpetuation. The only way to preserve Spirit is for it to stand all alone. Both Daoism and Buddhism promise escape from decay. But Su Shi admits misgivings about both choices. Unable to make a commitment, he opts to forget both and escape to an alternative destination – the land of wine where Tao Qian sojourned. Yet, being drunk is not forever. Ultimately man must face his fate, soberly and alone. In the looming shadow of death, he regrets the futility of his engagements with the world, his traces littered around like toys. Praise or blame depends on others, not on him. In the *Book of Changes*, an aged Confucius comes to see a world as a harmonious given. Su Shi, also aged and commenting upon the *Changes*, likely abjures any further thought or worry.

The active immersion in transience is an insight boasted in many of Su Shi's Hainan poems, and is often admired by commentators as representing his ultimate spiritual achievement. It finds expression in, for instance, a triad of poems titled "Three Comforts in the Life of Exile" (Zheju sanshi 謫居三適),<sup>132</sup> celebrating respectively combing one's hair in the morning wind, napping below the window at noon, and bathing one's feet warm at night. All these comforts have a tactile quality. They are quiet, physical pleasures that will only permeate a peaceful body. With these poems of ostensible ease, Su Shi rhetorically transformed a life of hardship into a flow of enjoyable moments.

By means of mental exercise, a strict regimen and physiological alchemical practices, Su lived to see the general amnesty in 1100, which was announced to celebrate Huizong's 徽宗 (1082–1135, r. 1100–1126) enthronement. Once across the strait, Su Shi wrote many social poems for the Buddhist monks he encountered on his northbound return, in which he expressed insights gained from his experiences of exile. In a poem to a Chan master in Qianzhou 虔州 (now Ganzhou, Jiangxi Province), he expatiates on his understanding of time:

未來不可招  
已過那容遣  
中間見在心  
一一風輪轉

What is yet to come cannot be summoned;  
what has passed can no longer be dispatched.  
Midway is the mind of transient presence,  
which turns and turns like a wheel in the wind.<sup>133</sup>

The active immersion in transience keeps the mind constantly engaged midway between a bygone past and an unforeseeable future. This view is indebted to the Tiantai Sect's doctrine of the "Threefold Truth", as discussed in Chapter One. This heart that settles in the midway – the truth of conventional existence – responds to every puff of wind with readiness and alertness. One's

<sup>132</sup> Su Shi, "Zheju sanshi sanshou", *SSSJ*, 41.2285–7.

<sup>133</sup> Su Shi, "Mingri Nanchan heshi budao [...]" 明日南禪和詩不到 [...], *SSSJ*, 45.2436.

physical body is thus transported into utter spontaneity. Once arrived at this state of being, one shall actively maintain it to the end of one's life, until death snatches it all.

### Coda

Death indeed caught Su Shi by surprise – he fell ill with malaria soon after he arrived in Changzhou 常州 (in modern Jiangsu Province), where he planned to retire. Ironically, his philosophical ‘return’ to settle in the southern territories prolonged his life, but his physical return to the central plains brought death. A poem, said to have been written on his deathbed, declares:

大患緣有身  
無身則無疾  
平生笑羅什  
神呪真浪出

The greatest suffering comes from having the body;  
without the body, there is no more disease.  
All my life I have been laughing at Kumārajīva –  
whose magic spells [on his deathbed] were truly a  
waste.<sup>134</sup>

The official biography of Kumārajīva, the Kuchean monk and great translator, relates that he tried to deter death by incanting magic spells.<sup>135</sup> Despite Su Shi's avid practice of Daoist alchemy, Kumārajīva's attempt struck him as laughable, since an enlightened being should eliminate even the distinction between life and death. It seems that, for him, there was a fine line between cultivating the physical being with care, and fending off death by magic. To borrow Ji Kang's crop analogy, the former is to water the seedling, so that it may fulfil its natural life span; the latter is to artificially revive the seedling when its number is already up. A man subscribing to the doctrine of provisional spontaneity must resign when his fate is finally known.

<sup>134</sup> Su Shi, “Da Jingshan Lin zhanglao” 答徑山琳長老, *SSSJ*, 45.2459.

<sup>135</sup> See Kumārajīva's biography in “Yishuzhuan” 藝術傳, Fang Xuanling, *Jinshu*, 95.2502. Authentic or not, this story recounts the close affinity of early Buddhism with magic, when high-ranking monks, especially those of foreign origin, were often magicians and miracle workers.